

"Contraband" camps

These early refugees from enslavement became known as "contraband of war," a phrase coined by Brigadier General Benjamin Butler, commander of Fortress Monroe in Virginia. It meant that people did not have to be returned to their enslavers as fugitives under federal law.

The men and women who fled enslavement deprived the Confederacy of vital labor. Enslaved people had raised the crops that fed the troops and tended the horses and mules used for combat and transportation. Without them, the Confederate war effort was severely weakened.

However, the fate of contrabands varied considerably from one theater of war to another. Many of the formerly enslaved people were rounded up and placed in special "contraband camps," where sanitation was poor and medical care even worse. Death rates were as high as 25 percent.

In 1861–63, the camps followed the advances of the Union armies, and as time wore on, conditions improved slightly, as Union officers found employment for large numbers of contrabands. The men worked as dockworkers, pioneers, trench-diggers, teamsters, and personal servants, and some of the women served as cooks and laundresses for the soldiers. As such, they performed the same functions as an enslaved person did for the Confederate armies, but at least they earned a "wage," even though this could simply be room, board, and clothing. The families of the employed lived in the local camp or hung around the margins of the Union picket lines.